



Separation Support

Premium practice worksheet

SEPARATION SUPPORT - LESSON 04

Make your leaving cues boring again.

This worksheet helps owners reduce the meaning of departure triggers such as keys, shoes, bags, jackets, door touches, and walking toward the exit.

TRAINER NOTE

If the dog starts to worry before you even leave, departure cues need their own training plan.

START HERE

Dog: _____

Date: _____

Owner: _____

Best reward: _____

1 What success looks like

By the end of this lesson, the owner can practice common departure cues at low intensity and keep the dog calm through short, repeatable reps.

2 Practice plan

1

List the triggers

Identify which cues make your dog start watching, shadowing, whining, or escalating.

2

Break the cue down

Practice tiny pieces such as touching the shoes, lifting the keys, or walking toward the door.

3

Repeat calm reps

Reset and repeat only while the dog remains relaxed or quickly recovers.

4

Mix and vary

Use different cues in low-stress combinations only after each cue becomes less



Separation Support

Departure Cue Desensitization

3 Supplies and setup

Supplies needed

- ☐ Common departure items like keys, jacket, bag, or shoes
- ☐ Treats if needed for calm pairing
- ☐ Observation log
- ☐ A quiet training period with no real departure immediately afterward

Set up before you start

- ☐ Choose only one or two departure cues per session.
- ☐ Practice when you are not actually leaving for a long absence.
- ☐ Keep reps short and boring so the cues lose predictive value.

4 Departure cue practice tracker

Date	Cue practiced	Intensity	Dog response	Recovered quickly	Next step

5 5-day practice micro plan

Day 1

Set baseline

Find the easiest version and keep it calm.

Day 2

Repeat wins

Practice the same setup until it looks smooth.

Day 3

Add one tiny step

Add only one small challenge if yesterday

Day 4

Hold or simplify

If your puppy struggled, make today easier.

Day 5

Review notes

Choose the safest next step from your log.



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6 Common mistakes and quick fixes

Common mistakes

- Practicing a cue and then immediately leaving for real.
- Combining too many hard cues too soon.
- Ignoring subtle pre-departure stress signs.
- Keeping reps going after the dog is already struggling.

If this happens, try this

- If the dog reacts to touching the cue only, make the rep smaller and repeat there.
- If multiple cues are hard, train them separately before combining them.
- If the dog stays concerned, reduce intensity and increase the number of easy reps.

7 Ready to progress?

- ☐ I know which departure cues bother my dog most.
- ☐ I can break a cue into smaller pieces.
- ☐ I am ending reps while the dog is still comfortable.
- ☐ I know which cue is easiest to keep practicing tomorrow.

HOMEWORK

Practice one or two departure cues for several short sessions this week and record which cue became less meaningful first.

8 Owner reflection

Biggest win: _____

What made it easier: _____

What should I repeat tomorrow: _____

QUESTIONS FOR YOUR FITDOG TRAINER

What should I make easier? _____

What should I practice again? _____

What is the next realistic step? _____